

Back To The Net

I apologise for that little diversion, but it was necessary. For all of you parents out there who are reading this article in disbelief, and those of you who are saying “My son/daughter would never do/talk about that!”, I have a simple path towards the light.

Many of you have kids who use instant messengers such as Yahoo! Messenger, MSN Messenger, and others. Here's what to do:

1. Get access to a computer away from home, or in your own room.

2. Sign-up for a Yahoo! account—only, *don't do it with your real name*. Fill in a girl's name, and put your age at 15.

3. Make sure your login name reflects that you're a girl.

4. Get Yahoo! Messenger—a very popular instant messenger.

5. At the time of day when your son/daughter usually uses the Net, go to one of the chat rooms in the regional group “India.”

6. Announce that you are a 15-year-old girl from <your city> looking to make friends.

7. If you have a Webcam, turn it on and wait for the solicitations for cybersex (sexually-oriented, titillating chat) to come pouring in.

Do the above. You'll get a first-hand experience of what your son and/or daughter might be exposed to online every day!

No More Internet For You!

I know that's the strong reaction many of you would likely have, but that would be wrong on just so many levels! First off, the Internet is a lot more help than it is destructive—think of all the useful information your kids have access to. Secondly, you can't cage your kids up forever, and they're going to start working soon enough; knowing how to use the Internet productively is almost a job requisite now—so let them learn! Finally, kids are almost *immune* to this sort of stuff. You wouldn't believe the kind of stuff that your kids *don't* get shocked or scandalised by! You may be appalled at what you see, especially if you did the little exercise I mentioned above. But your kids will just take it in their stride. They are a lot less susceptible to being fooled, duped, conned, lured, etc., than *you* are online!

The Tables Have Turned

Parents are no longer the all-knowing keepers of secrets. Today, the younger generation knows a lot more about computers than anyone else, especially those who are growing up with it. Take my parents for example: I write for the country's premier technology magazine, but my parents know nothing about computers, and quite honestly, they couldn't care less. Had I been 10 years younger, and up to the mischief that is part and parcel with teenagers, I'd be doing a lot of things my parents would *tch-tch* at!

It's the older generations that need to take on the responsibility of learning enough about the technology that is ruling the lives of the younger ones. Some would go so far as to say that it's not the sex education of the young ones we need to worry about, but the *tech education* of the elders.

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The Tech Education

On the Internet, as we've mentioned earlier, we're exposed to adult content through several avenues. The most common is e-mail spam. Since we have an unwritten “free” software policy in India—not the freeware type, the *freeware* type—almost all of us go searching for cracks, serials, key generators and the like. Unfortunately, almost all warez sites have ads from pornographic Web sites. Teenagers often end up clicking these links, and are promptly exposed to the most explicit of adult content.

Chat rooms are another source of exposure to adult behaviour—even from 15-year-olds. In the exercise I mentioned earlier, I asked you to pretend to be a 15-year-old girl; that was to show you that although trying to solicit a 15-year-old for sex is a crime in almost every country in the world, it will still not stop people from trying to find out your address and your phone number, and convince you to have cybersex with them.

Doing that in real life with a 15-year-old would most definitely land them in jail, but on the Internet, who cares? Besides the sexual predators, there are bots—automated programs—spread across almost every chat room online, which display URLs to adult sites, a form of advertising almost all porn sites indulge in.

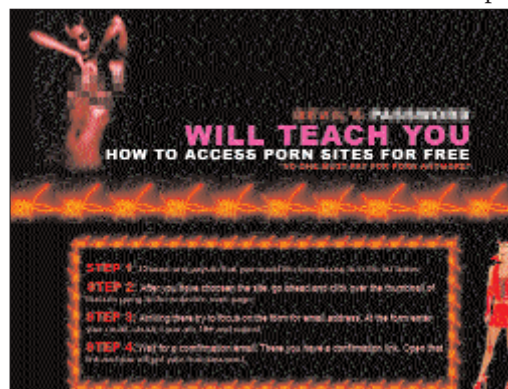
Another area where you will come across pornography is when using a search engine—your son or daughter might just do a search on the word “sex” or something similar, out of curiosity—and will be bombarded by links to pornographic sites. And apart from this, even casual surfing will land you at an adult site sooner or later—such is today's Internet.

The Sex Education

There are a lot of evils that teens and pre-teens need to be wary of when online. Whether or not you visit porn sites is purely your business. It is only for you, your parents, relatives, and society to decide whether this is wrong or not. However, be warned that a lot of adult sites will dupe you into spending money or compromising your security. Let's take a look at the most common traps set out for you.

Diallers: You will find thousands of sites that advertise free porn provided you use their dialler to connect to them. They charge you per minute in dollars for any calls you make, and this is *not* counting the ISD charges of connecting to the US. Make sure you never install diallers from porn sites: they might even contain Trojans or worms.

E-mail: A lot of sites offer free hardcore pictures in the form of e-mail newsletters. Almost all the time, this is just a ruse to get you



An example: A site that claims to teach people how to get porn for free! We got this link via spam e-mail, but it's also popular on warez sites